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Thamesmead Community Association

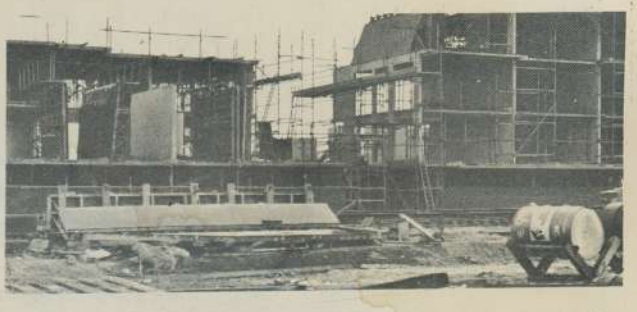
INSIGHT

MAY, 1970 No. 1

Safety Officer Kevin Cullen reports

MIND THAT CHILD!

Fun and games could end in tragedy



IT MIGHT be considered "great fun" to clamber and swing across the scaffolding, but great danger lurks amid the hoists and ladders. (Picture: PACE, Charlton).

USING four ladders and climbing high over scaffolding, a Thamesmead site foreman rescued two children aged three and six years old. It happened on the third floor at Block 13 (the bit that juts out) Harrow Manorway.

The six-year-old "ringleader" said: "We were playing," adding that "it was great fun."

Another incident concerning two youngsters aged three and four occurred at Radley House. Here they were ushered down from the ninth floor where they had been sitting happily on the hoist run. "A great machine," they said.

ROPE TRICK

The most dangerous escapade to date was at Tavy Bridge by the shopping centre. A boy aged eight was climbing up the scaffolding trying to perform the Indian rope trick and vanish into thin air. He was 30 feet above ground level.

These incidents could easily have ended in tragedy. Parents are asked to co-operate in keeping their children off the sites.

Every effort is being made by the contractors to make the building sites as safe as possible but, in the end, it is up to parents to ensure safe supervision of their children.



ON WINDY RIDGE . . .

These youngsters were pictured enjoying themselves on Windy Ridge, Thamesmead.

To celebrate the first issue of Insight, the editor would like to present each child here with a half-plate size copy of the picture.

Parents concerned should contact Patrick Forbes, 4 Coralline Walk (Phone 310-3860) with name and address. Patrick will be pleased to forward the prints. (Picture: PACE, Charlton).

Kentish
Thamesmead's Local Paper
INDEPENDENT

INSIGHT

THE official organ of the Thamesmead Community Association.

EDITOR : Patrick Forbes, 4 Coralline Walk, Thamesmead, to whom all correspondence (editorial or advertising) must be sent.



Patrick's Piece

Mesmedaath is dead!

MESMEDAATH is dead. Long live Insight! We are very excited at this new development of the TCA. There are no regrets at the honourable death of Insight's predecessor.

No more staying up all night typing stencils, operating the duplicator and stapling sheets together.

Now, thanks to the generous help of the Kentish Independent, the donkey work is removed, and I'm sure you'll agree, a much brighter and interesting news sheet is the result.

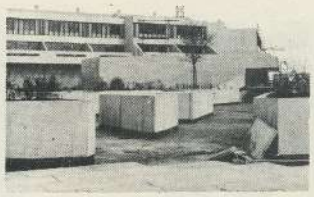
One important facet to the birth of Insight is there will now be a deadline for your contributed copy, as we can't keep the presses idle as one group drags its feet with its news.

If copy is not in by the 15th of the month before publication date, don't come crying about being left out. Thanks!

As Thamesmead develops and as the population grows, there'll be no difficulty in enlarging the paper—so long as proportionate increases in advertising keep the costs down.

So this is the beginning, or rather the second chapter, of a story that began last December with the unpronounceable "Mesmedaath."

Incidentally, hands up all those who didn't realise that Mesmedaath was an anagram of Thamesmead?



SHOPS being built. Who will occupy them? That is the question! (Picture: Derek Baker).

SHOPS

WE STILL hope for some shops to open in June. Last December, the G.L.C. promised to apply pressure on traders who were reluctant to open because of the small number of prospective shoppers.

Apparently, it is policy for the G.L.C. not to reveal the names of firms who will be taking shops. This makes it difficult for us to sell them advertising in Insight.

Problems please

SINCE the Citizens' Advice Bureau located in the Information Office opened last December, all manner of problems have been handled. These have ranged from general information to advice and help with personal, family and employment troubles.

When Insight interviewed Mr. Ron Ferguson, a chemist from Bexleyheath who is on duty on Thursday evenings, a quick count revealed that 41 enquiries have been received.

Inevitably, when a new bureau opens, it takes time for its services to become known. A leaflet explaining the CAB was folded within this current Insight issue.

Finding staff to man Citizens' Advice Bureaux is always a headache for the organisers. If any reader has time to spare, don't hesitate to contact Mrs. Sharpley, General Secretary of the Bexley Council of Social Service, 35 The Broadway, Bexleyheath (304-0911), or drop in to see Mr. Ferguson or Mr. Pinn (Mondays) at your local CAB.

CORN FLAKES

NOW, FOLKS — what would you do with a couple of dozen empty plastic yoghurt cartons, some lengths of garden wire, some oddments of cloth, string and glue? You make dolls, of course (reports David Manktelow).

But, on the other hand, supposing you were given three dozen empty corn flake packets with plenty of paint and glue? Simple—you make a model of Coralline Walk!

Other imaginative creations from the minds and hands of more than 70 junior children who crowded Thamesmead's Three Day Holiday Club at Abbey Primary School, were an African village, Red Indian wigwams and a cluster of igloos.

Add to these some artistic work with paint and brush, and scores of cut-out pictures and you have a scene of worthwhile activity and fun—all helping us to learn about "The World God Made" (the theme of the occasion) and our place in it.

There will be more activities by the Holiday Club during the summer break, just at the point when the kids plead: "Mum, what can we do?"

More details later.

WIVES CLUB

AS members have shown great interest in keeping fit, the Thamesmead Wives' Club are starting a Keep Fit Club at William Temple Hall, Eynsham Drive, on Tuesday evenings at 8 p.m. starting on Tuesday, 5 May (writes Mrs. S. Rendall).

During March, they held a lingerie party at which some of the mums became models—modelling nightwear.

At the next meeting on 27 May (8 p.m.), Mrs. Gilbey, a consultant from Boots No. 7, will be the guest speaker.

CHESS CLUB

YOU could have heard a pin drop in the Information Centre when the Chess Club held their first meeting during April. Jim Murray had managed with great skill to obtain some chess sets for the evening.

The members ranged from learners to veterans. So with thinking caps on it was eyes down, pawn to king four etc. New members will be very welcome. The club meets every Tuesday at 8 p.m.

WATCH IT!

THAMESMEAD'S home beat policeman Constable Ron Lathwell, warns cyclists to make sure their machines are securely locked when unattended. He told Insight that thefts of milk and groceries left outside dwellings are occurring and that children are taking far too many risks on the site.

P.C. Lathwell can be contacted through Belvedere Police Station (Erith 32214) for non-urgent matters. In emergency, dial 999 and ask for Police.



MICKELBOROUGHS
REMOVALS and STORAGE
'Anywhere with Every Care"
72 Plumstead Rd., S.E.18
854-3854/9611

'Sometimes I travel to London. I see colours, some painted houses. Colours have not been planned for Thamesmead.'

A GERMAN VISITOR TALKS TO INSIGHT

TOWN OF GREY

HELGA Trosken, a minister of the Protestant Church in Germany, has been studying Christian life and work in Thamesmead. What are her thoughts and impressions as she strolls around the current pride of south of the Thames?

Pretty mixed as Insight discovered when we went along to see her the other day...

"My first impression was marvellous," she said. "On the film of Thamesmead I saw the yacht harbour, blue skies, happy people, pleasant landscape and laughing children in the playgrounds near the houses. I saw the flowers, the trees and, of course the sun was shining."

She smiled. "But this was the Thamesmead of the future."

What of 1970, we asked?

"I have been walking around the site. My shoes became muddy and wet. One day there'll be beautiful lakes in place of the puddles and mud, I'm told.

"I saw children playing on the walkways. Is it really true that the walkways are the only playing spaces in stage one? Of course not. But more use the walkways than the designated playground, it seems.

"I quickly memorised the number of the house I'm living in, otherwise I would have been quite unable to distinguish it from all the others. The dwellings all look alike."



THE Rev. Helga Trosken from Germany pictured during a visit to Lesnes Abbey. near Thamesmead (Picture: Derek Baker).

What of the architecture?

"Sometimes I travel up to London," Helga Trosken went on. "You see, I like to look at the green, the trees, some colours, some painted houses.

"Colours have not been planned for Thamesmead. Could it be that the G.L.C. planners never have to live here?

"People don't have to walk around Thamesmead—they can be blown around. Hats off to the planners, so to speak!"

Helga pointed to the skyline. "Grey houses, concrete, grey walkways, similar shapes. Does all this attract people and excite them with the thought of living here?"

Which way will Thamesmead go? As it is today or like the thrilling film?

Helga smiled again: "I wish I knew."

HON. SEC. SAYS:

SINCE the constitution for the TCA was accepted in June, 1969, we have had our fair share of disappointments. The number of successes and partial successes have outweighed the disappointments.

All this warrants the existence of an association which can speak for the whole community in today's bureaucratic society. Look, briefly, at some of the details :—

A safe access to the primary school has been erected, all faulty toilets changed, a Christmas party held for the young and a pantomime visit for older children, and endeavours made to get storage room charges removed.

PRESSURE

Continual pressure is being put on the G.L.C. regarding rain penetration, and the cleaning of communal stairs and windows. Garages have been opened earlier to ease parking problems. The standing charges for electricity have been checked and lowered in some dwellings.

The G.L.C. have also been approached regarding water supply for car-washing, garage rents and lighting, storage heaters, seats on walkways, rent office opening hours, emergency services, protective barriers, bar for community centre, rent anomalies, mice, public phone boxes, lighting, lifts, road signs and drainage.

Most of these are in the pipeline and answers are expected soon.

Talks were also arranged from Mr. J. Wellbeloved, M.P. for Erith, Dr. Higgins on health, and the police on security.

Jack Goodair,
Hon Sec., TCA.

GOOD SIGNS

APPROVED road signs warning drivers of the presence of schoolchildren, have been ordered and should be in position in Lensbury Way at the time of going to Press.

Abbey Arms

31 Harrow Manorway, S.E.2. 854 0134

'For the drink of your choice see Norman or Joyce'

HOT and COLD SNACKS
WITH A 'COURAGE' Light

CUFFS of Woolwich
QUALITY SERVICE

INTEREST FREE H.P.

For Limited Period

Delivering in local areas everyday

THE INDEPENDENT STORE FOR PERSONAL SERVICE

Powis Street, Woolwich, S.E.18

YOUR SWORD'S BENT!

AFTER a chapter of accidents had hit members of St. Katherine's Fencing Club on their way to Abbey School—one had his car stolen and another had thermostat trouble—a great evening of cut and thrust followed.

All eight members of the club arrived in one car to take part in a demonstration promoted by the Thamesmead Youth Club. Some 70 teenagers, parents and children made up an enthusiastic audience.

The Rev. David Platt was unable to attend, but journalist Bob Miles stepped in to introduce the proceedings. This included the story of fencing as founded by Henry VIII—seemed the latter had time for other things...

SABRE

Then came a feast of parries, ripostes with foil (the only weapon used by female fencers), epee and sabre.

One small child, used no doubt, to perfection in all things, called out: "Your sword is bent!" Later, one of the judges nearly had his foot sliced away.

Then came the call for volunteers. Up stepped Ford Sexton, "the hottest thing since Errol Flynn," and gave rather more than he got. "Cut his liver out," said a member of the audience entering into the spirit of the occasion.

Among other bouts, one between Eileen Brown and Margaret Eames, inspired some Youth Club wags to remark that here was a way of resolving difficulties encountered in committee work.

A certain arthritic old curate and a dashing Baptist Minister were photographed in warlike positions—not, it must be reported, with one another.

So successful was this venture that it is strongly rumoured that Thamesmead is to have its own fencing club in the near future. Keep a sharp look out, folks!

TO CATCH A THIEF

IF you see a suspicious-looking character clutching a pair of black wellington boots (size 13, kid-size), and downing a carton of double cream and, at the same time, making off with an expensive toy, let Insight know.

The suspect has been active in Coralline Walk, and all attempts to catch him or her have, so far, been of no avail.



HE WANTS TO PLAY SAFE!

MEET Stephen Forbes, the youngest member of the Insight team. Stephen, who is just two and a half years old, is still waiting for a safe playing space NEAR Coralline Walk. The G.L.C. promised to look into this problem last December. No news yet.

ODD JOBS?

THE Youth Club are willing and anxious to do any odd jobs. Anything legal will be considered including car-washing and gardening. If you have a job they can do, contact Janette Ries, 27 Clewer House, or Margaret Eames, 17 Coralline Walk.

GERRY BRIGHT WRITES...



ON BEHALF of the TCA, I welcome all new arrivals to Thamesmead. Quite a number of newcomers already know about the TCA through Press and TV reports.

During the first year, the Committee has had numerous individual and group complaints rectified on behalf of members. In this first edition of Insight, secretary Jack Goodair (see Page 3) writes on some of these accomplishments.

One of the prime aims of the association is, of course, for the welfare of you all. We are out to improve the social, moral and educational life within the community at Thamesmead.

There are a number of clubs or sections in the framework of the TCA. These include a Wives Club and a Youth Club.

Mrs. Pauline Hooper, one of our active committee members, has attended Goldsmith's College to qualify as a playgroup leader. In September, when our clubroom is completed, Pauline will form a playgroup for small children.

Our Senior Citizens are not forgotten, and regular afternoon functions for these valued members will be organised.

It is hoped that we will have arranged for our junior boys between the ages of nine and 16 years to be accepted into local league football next season.

Remember, membership of the TCA costs only 2s. 6d. per month per family or 30s. a year. I look forward to seeing you all at the monthly meetings held in the Information Centre.

Gerry Bright,
Chairman, TCA.

OUR PRIME AIMS

BIG SURVEY

INSIGHT understands that the Research and Intelligence Unit of the G.L.C. plan to carry out a survey of all Thamesmead tenants in connection with plans for provision of adequate education and employment services as well as health and social services.

New tenants will be interviewed on the day of letting and arrangements will be made to see everyone already in Thamesmead within the next few months.

Insight would like to point out that the survey is being carried out in strictly confidential terms.

BOOKS

BEXLEY Library Service hope to have a mobile library visiting Thamesmead every week sometime during Fridays. This will happen when mechanical trouble with the vehicle has been sorted out.

Something to sell?

Thamesmead residents are welcome to advertise unwanted furniture or other goods in Insight free of charge. Simply write your advertisement on a plain piece of paper and hand it to the editor.

In addition, the Kentish Independent will accept advertisements from Thamesmead residents at a special rate of 9d. per word. Please write them on plain paper and send them to the Kentish Independent at 39, Wellington Street, S.E.18., together with your name and address.

½ a minute away...

ARC ELECTRICS

Everything electrical from batteries to colour televisions.

15% CASH DISCOUNT

ON ALL DOMESTIC APPLIANCES

19 - 21 HARROW MANORWAY, S.E.2. 854 9046

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